

The start from scratch approach

We have all gotten our beliefs about the world from a variety of sources. Some are based on serious thought and investigation. Some are based on what our parents told us. Some are based on what our friends told us. Some are probably based on nothing at all. If we want to really figure out what we should and should not believe, we need to avoid taking anything for granted. Instead, we should assume nothing, and test all of our beliefs against some standard to see which ones we should keep, and which ones we should get rid of.

The natural next question is: what is the standard by which we should decide which of our beliefs to keep, and which to discard?

Here again Descartes gives us an answer.

“Reason now leads me to believe that I should hold back my assent from opinions which are not completely certain and indubitable just as carefully as I do from those which are patently false. So, for the purpose of rejecting my opinions, it will be enough if I find in each of them some reason for doubt.”

What would it mean for you to find in someone belief a reason for doubt?

Here's an example. Suppose that I introduce you to my dog, which is a small black and white dog with curly hair. Suppose you form the belief that my dog is a poodle.

But now suppose that you find out that there are small black and white dogs with curly hair which are not poodles. In particular, Havanese dogs are quite popular in the area, and also of that size with those markings.

It looks like you would now have found a reason for doubting your initial belief.

More precisely, it looks like you would have realized that there is a possibility of your belief being false which you are unable to rule out.

And, as the quote from Descartes suggests, it seems reasonable for you now to stop believing that my dog is a poodle, and instead to suspend judgement about whether it is a poodle, or a Havanese, or perhaps some other small back and white type of dog.

This suggests the following rule of belief:

Doubt $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If you cannot rule out a situation which would make P false, you should not believe P.

It seems like we implicitly rely on this rule of belief all of the time. Often if someone points out some overlooked way in which a certain belief could be false, that's reason enough to stop holding the belief.

Would this rule out all basic beliefs? It seems like it would not. Consider these beliefs that I have.

I exist.

$$2+2=4.$$

All triangles
have three
sides.

I am feeling
cold right now.

Imagine that I don't have arguments for any of these. It still seems like, just by thinking about them, I can be certain that each is true. There's no possibility of any of them being false which I can't rule out.



The start from scratch approach

We have all gotten our beliefs about the world from a variety of sources. Some are based on serious thought and investigation. Some are based on what our parents told us. Some are based on what our friends told us. Some are probably based on nothing at all. If we want to really figure out what we should and should not believe, we need to avoid taking anything for granted. Instead, we should assume nothing, and test all of our beliefs against some standard to see which ones we should keep, and which ones we should get rid of.

The natural next question is: what is the standard by which we should decide

which to keep, and which to discard?



‘Reason now leads me to believe that I should hold back my assent from opinions which are not completely certain and indubitable just as carefully as I do from those which are patently false. So, for the purpose of rejecting my opinions, it will be enough if I find in each of them some reason for doubt.’

Here's an example. Suppose that I introduce you to my dog, which is a

that my dog is a puddle.

small black and white dog with curly hair. Support for the belief

But now suppose that you find out that there are small black and white

are quite popular in the area, and also of that size with the marking.

dogs with curly hair which are not poodles. In particular, Havanese dogs

It looks like you would not have found a reason for doubting your initial

beliefs.

possibility of your belief being false which you are unable to rule out.

More precisely, it looks like you would have realized that there is a

And, as the quote from Descartes suggests, it seems reasonable for you

judgment about whether it is a pod. Have, perhaps some

other small black and white type of dog.

now to stop believing that my dog is a poodle, and instead to suspend



Doubt $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If you cannot rule out a situation which would make P false, you should not believe P .

It seems like we implicitly rely on this rule of belief all the time. Often if

some points overlaid way in which a certain belief could be

false, that's reason enough to stop holding the belief.

these beliefs that have.



Would this rule out all basophilic? It seems likely it would not. Consider

I exist.

$$2+2=4.$$

All triangles
have three
sides.

I am feeling
cold right now.

Imagine that I don't have arguments for any of these. It still seems like,

possibility of any of them being false which I can't rule out.

just by thinking about them, I can be certain that each is true. There's no

imagine that I don't have proofs of any of these. It still seems like, just by

possibility of any of them being false which I can't rule out.

thinking about them, I can be certain that each is true. There's no

I exist.

$$2+2=4.$$

All triangles
have three
sides.

I am feeling
cold right now.